



WEEK FOUR · MODULE ONE

The Art of Anticipation and Service

Solving the problem before it becomes one, and disappearing before you are thanked

THE PRIVATE CONCIERGE ACADEMY

Maison Amarine · Confidential · For the use of our mentees only

CONTENTS

Contents

I	What anticipation actually is
II	The three levels of service
III	Observation: the discipline nobody teaches
IV	The preference file
V	The anticipation loop: observe, infer, prepare, withdraw
VI	Reading a room, and reading a mood
VII	The second option, and the pre-mortem
VIII	Standards, mise en place, and the reset
IX	The limits of anticipation
.	Glossary
.	Self-assessment
.	Further study

HOW TO STUDY THIS MODULE

Week 3 was about what you must never do. This week is about what makes you irreplaceable.

Anticipation is not intuition, and it is not a gift. It is a method, and the method is written down in this module.

Your deliverable this week is your own anticipation playbook. Read with a pen.

CHAPTER I

What anticipation is

And why it is a method, not a talent

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Define anticipation precisely, and distinguish it from guessing.

Understand why anticipation is the single skill that decides your salary.

I.1 · A definition

DEFINITION

Anticipation. The systematic construction of a future need from present evidence, resolved before the principal becomes aware that the need existed.

Read the definition again and notice the three parts. **Systematic:** it is a process, repeatable, teachable, not a flash of inspiration. **From present evidence:** it is built from what you observed, not from what you imagined. **Before they become aware:** that is the whole art. If they had to notice, you were late.

I.2 · The uncomfortable truth about your value

Competence is not rare. A household can hire competence in a week. Any decent agency can send them three people who will book flights correctly, manage a renovation and never lose a receipt.

What is rare, and what is paid, is the person who removes friction from a life before the friction arrives. That is the difference between an excellent assistant at 70,000 and an estate manager at 185,000. It is not more work. It is a different kind of attention.

I.3 · The sentence you are working towards

THE MEASURE OF THE WHOLE WEEK

The principal never says thank you, because the principal never knew there was anything to thank you for.

If you need to be thanked, you will not be able to do this work. The praise you are looking for is silence, and a life that runs.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Anticipation is a method built on evidence, not a talent and not a guess.

Competence is cheap. Removing friction before it arrives is what is actually paid.

The reward for perfect anticipation is that nobody notices. Make peace with that now.

CHAPTER II

The three levels of service

And why only one of them is a career

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Place any action on the reactive, proactive or anticipatory scale.

Recognise which level you currently operate at, honestly.

Level	What it looks like, and what it is worth
Reactive	They ask, you deliver, well and quickly. This is the floor. It is what "good service" means everywhere else in the world, and it is entirely replaceable. Paid: an ordinary salary.
Proactive	You see a need forming and you offer. "Would you like me to arrange a car?" Better. But notice what you have done: you have handed them a decision. You have made them think. Paid: a good salary.
Anticipatory	The car is downstairs. The bag is in it. Nothing was asked, nothing was offered, nothing was discussed, and there was no decision to make. Paid: what this profession actually pays.

2.1 · Why the middle level is a trap

Most of the ambitious people in this field get stuck at proactive, and they are proud of it. They think that offering is service. But every offer is a small tax on the principal's attention, and their attention is the scarcest thing they own.

Every question you ask is a small failure of preparation. That is harsh, and it is not entirely fair, and you should still write it down. Some questions are unavoidable and this module will tell you exactly which ones. But the count matters. Track it for a week and you will improve without doing anything else.

2.2 · The exception, which is important

Anticipation never applies to matters of consent, money above your threshold, the children's safety, or anything irreversible. There you **always ask**, always, and asking is not a

failure: it is the rule. We will return to this in Chapter IX, and it is the chapter that keeps people employed.

CHAPTER III

Observation

The discipline nobody teaches, because everyone assumes it

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Practise structured observation rather than passive noticing.

Know the six categories of signal, and record them.

3.1 · The difference between noticing and observing

Everyone notices. Almost nobody observes. Noticing is passive, it happens to you, and it is gone by evening. Observation is deliberate, categorised, and **written down within the hour**. If it is not written down, it did not happen, because you will not remember it in March.

3.2 · The six categories

Category	What you are collecting
Preference	The coffee, the pillow, the seat on the aircraft, the side of the bed, the temperature of the room, the brand of water. Trivial individually. Decisive collectively.
Pattern	What happens every Tuesday. Who calls before a difficult trip. What always runs late. Patterns are where anticipation actually comes from.
Threshold	How much lateness is tolerated. What level of spend needs approval. How much noise is acceptable before nine. Every house has thresholds and no house writes them down.
Aversion	What they will never say aloud but never tolerate twice. A tone. A supplier. A flower. An assistant who explains too much.
Rhythm	Energy across the day. When they are approachable. When they are not. When decisions get made and when they get postponed.
Anomaly	Anything that departs from the pattern. An anomaly is either a problem forming or a preference changing, and both matter urgently.

3.3 · The discipline

Ten minutes, at the end of every day, without exception. You write what you observed in the six categories. Not opinions. Not feelings. Not "she seemed annoyed". Facts: "left the table before coffee, second time this week, both times after a call with the London office."

Do this for ninety days and you will know things about the household that nobody has told you and nobody could have told you. **That file is your career.**

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Observe in six categories: preference, pattern, threshold, aversion, rhythm, anomaly.

Ten minutes a day, in writing, facts only. Never opinions, never emotions.

Anomalies are urgent. They are either a problem forming or a preference changing.

CHAPTER IV

The preference file

What goes in it, what never does, and where it lives

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Build a preference file that is useful and that could survive being read aloud in court.

Understand the confidentiality rules that govern it.

4.1 · The rule that governs everything in this chapter

Everything you learned in Week 3 applies here without exception. **The preference file is the most sensitive document you will ever hold**, and it is the one people are most careless with, because it feels administrative.

THE TEST, BEFORE ANYTHING IS WRITTEN

Write nothing you would not be comfortable reading aloud to the principal, in their study, tomorrow morning.

No health. No relationships. No finances. No judgements. No shorthand you would have to explain. If the file were found, it should be boring.

4.2 · The structure

Section	Contents
The person	How they take coffee and tea, at what hour. Water, still or sparkling, brand, temperature. Breakfast. Allergies and dietary rules, recorded exactly, never approximately. Scents they cannot tolerate.
The house	Temperature by room. Lighting in the evening. Flowers: which, and which never. Music, or the absence of it. Who is allowed in which rooms, and when.
Travel	Airline, seat, cabin. Hotels: the property, the room, the floor, and the rooms they have refused. Cars: model, driver, temperature, whether conversation is welcome. What is always packed. What is never packed.

Section	Contents
The table	Wines, waters, coffee. The restaurants and the tables within them. The dishes they return to. The ones they sent back, once, and never mentioned.
Rhythm	The hours. When to approach and when not to. The day of the week that is always difficult, and why, if you know.
Standing decisions	Everything they have already decided so that they never have to decide it again. This section is the whole point of the file.

4.3 · Where it lives

In the channel the house has designated, and nowhere else. Not on your personal telephone. Not in your personal cloud. Not in a notebook that travels home with you in a handbag on a train.

When you leave the house, **it stays**. It is not yours, it was never yours, and taking it is theft of the most damaging kind. The professionals who take their preference file to the next house are the professionals who are never hired at that level again.

CHAPTER V

The anticipation loop

Four movements, in order, every time

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Run the loop deliberately until it becomes automatic.

Understand why the fourth movement is the one that separates professionals from staff.

Movement	What you actually do
1 · Observe	Collect the evidence. What is on the calendar. What was said this morning, and in what tone. What changed. What always happens next in this pattern.
2 · Infer	Construct the need. "She flies Thursday. She always calls her mother the evening before a long flight. She has never once found the charger in the bag she takes."
3 · Prepare	Resolve it, quietly, in advance, and prepare the second option in case the first fails. Prepared, not announced. Nothing is said.
4 · Withdraw	Say nothing. Take no credit. Do not hover in the doorway waiting for it to be noticed. Withdraw completely, and go and do the next thing.

5.1 · Why the fourth movement is the hard one

Anyone can be taught the first three. The fourth is where careers are made, and it is almost purely a matter of ego.

The person who prepares beautifully and then **lets it be known** that they prepared beautifully has undone the work. They have converted a smooth morning into a small debt of gratitude, and gratitude is a weight. You were hired to remove weight.

5.2 · The loop, worked through

Evidence

The inference, and the preparation

The principal has a board meeting Thursday at 09:00 in Geneva, and it is now Monday.

Thursday needs a suit. The suit was worn in Milan and has not been cleaned. The car must leave at 06:40, not 07:00, because the works on the airport road have not finished. The Geneva office has never once had still water in the room. All four of these are resolved on Monday, and none of them are mentioned.

The younger child has been quiet at breakfast for three days.

This is an anomaly, not a preference. You do not interpret it, you do not investigate it, and you certainly do not comfort the child in a way that positions you. You note it factually and you make sure the person whose responsibility it is has the opportunity to see it too. Anticipation has a boundary, and this is it.

Two suppliers have both said "next week" for the third time.

The renovation is going to miss its date. The principal does not yet know. You do not wait to be asked, and you do not present a disaster: you present the revised date, the reason in one sentence, and the two options, before they hear it from anyone else.

CHAPTER VI

Reading a room, and reading a mood

Without ever appearing to be reading anything

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Adjust your presence to the state of the room within seconds of entering it.

Never mistake mood for instruction.

6.1 · The scan

Every time you enter a room, before you speak, three seconds:

- **Who is here, and what is the relationship between them right now?** A room with a difficult conversation in it feels different, and you will feel it.
- **What is the energy?** Light, heavy, hurried, still. This decides your pace, your volume, and whether you speak at all.
- **Is this a moment for me, or should I not be here?** The correct answer, more often than new staff believe, is that you should not be here. Leave quietly and return in ten minutes.

6.2 · Matching, not mirroring

You match the room's register. In a light room you may be light. In a heavy room you become quiet, brief and efficient, and you do not attempt to lift the mood, because lifting the mood is a form of commentary and commentary is not your role.

6.3 · The rule that will save you

MOOD IS NOT INSTRUCTION

A principal who is irritated has not given you an order. A principal who is charming has not given you permission.

You read the mood in order to calibrate your presence, never in order to change your standards. The standards are the standards on the good days and on the bad ones, and that is precisely why they are worth something.

CHAPTER VII

The second option

And the pre-mortem, which is the most useful hour of your week

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Run a pre-mortem on anything that matters.

Always hold a second option, and never announce it.

7.1 · The pre-mortem

DEFINITION

The pre-mortem. Before the event, you assume it has already failed, and you write down why. Not a list of risks. A post-mortem of a failure that has not happened yet.

It takes twenty minutes and it is the single highest-return habit in this profession. The question is not "what could go wrong". The question is "**it went wrong. What was it?**" The second question produces specific answers, and the first produces vague ones.

7.2 · The three failures you are looking for

- **The single point of failure.** One car, one driver, one supplier, one flight, one key. Anything that exists once is a failure waiting for a date.
- **The assumption nobody has checked.** "The restaurant knows." Does it? Someone confirmed it, in writing, this week, with a name attached?
- **The handover.** Almost every failure in this work happens at a boundary: between you and the driver, the driver and the hotel, the office and the house. Nothing fails in the middle of a well-run system. It fails at the seams.

7.3 · The second option

For anything that matters, there is a second option. The second restaurant is held. The second car is on standby. The second flight is known, with the price and the time.

And it is **never announced**. You do not tell the principal that you have a backup, because telling them means telling them the primary might fail, and that is precisely the anxiety you were hired to remove. The second option is your private insurance, and its purpose is

that nothing ever appears to have gone wrong.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

The pre-mortem: assume it failed, then explain why. Twenty minutes, before anything that matters.

Failures live at the seams: handovers, boundaries, assumptions nobody confirmed.

Hold a second option for everything that matters, and never say a word about it.

CHAPTER VIII

Standards, mise en place, and the reset

The invisible architecture of a house that runs

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Understand the reset, and why it is done at night.

Hold a standard when nobody is watching, which is the only time it counts.

8.1 · Mise en place, borrowed from a better trade

DEFINITION

Mise en place. Everything in its place, before it is needed. From the kitchen, where it is the difference between a service that works and a service that collapses at eight o'clock.

In a house, it means the same thing. The bag is packed the night before. The documents are printed before the meeting, not during it. The car is fuelled on Sunday. **You do not do things when they are needed. You do them before, when nobody is watching, and that is why they appear effortless.**

8.2 · The reset

Every evening, the house returns to its baseline. Not because it is untidy: because a household that begins each day from the same state is a household in which nothing is ever lost, and nothing is ever hunted for at seven in the morning.

8.3 · The standard when nobody is watching

The wine is poured correctly when they are not in the room. The flowers are turned when the house is empty. The car is spotless on the day nobody is being driven anywhere.

This sounds like theatre and it is exactly the opposite of theatre. **A standard that is performed for an audience is not a standard, it is a display, and everyone in this world can tell the difference within a fortnight.**

CHAPTER IX

The limits of anticipation

The chapter that keeps you employed

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Recognise over-anticipation, presumption and the servile drift.

Know exactly where you always ask, without exception.

9.1 · Over-anticipation

Anticipation applied without evidence is guessing, and guessing that turns out well is worse than guessing that turns out badly, because it teaches you to do it again.

The staff member who books the restaurant they think the principal will love, having never once seen them eat there, has not anticipated anything. They have imposed a preference and called it service.

9.2 · Presumption

There is a line, and it is not subtle once you know it exists. On one side you are removing friction. On the other you are **making decisions about their life**, and no salary in this profession comes with that right.

You always ask, without exception

Why

Anything irreversible	A cancellation with a penalty, a signature, a purchase that cannot be returned, a message sent on their behalf. Irreversible means you ask, every time, even when the answer is obvious.
Money above your threshold	Every house has a figure. Learn yours in the first week and never test it. Being right about a spend you were not authorised to make is still a breach.
The children	Their movements, their health, their schooling, their friendships. You execute, and you do not initiate.
Anything involving other people's consent	You do not volunteer them, commit them, or share their information, however convenient it would be.

You always ask, without exception

Why

Anything you would rather they did not find out about

That instinct is not shyness. It is your judgement telling you the answer, and it is almost always right.

9.3 · The servile drift

Anticipation is a professional discipline, not an act of devotion. The person who begins to anticipate emotionally rather than operationally, who wants to be needed, who takes pleasure in being the only one who knows how the coffee is taken, is drifting towards exactly the trap you studied in Week 3.

You are anticipating a household, not a person. Hold that sentence. It is the difference between a long career and a short, intense one that ends without explanation.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Anticipation without evidence is guessing, and it is not your job.

Irreversible, expensive, involving the children, or involving anyone else's consent: you ask. Always.

You anticipate a household, not a person. The moment that inverts, you are in danger.

Glossary

Anticipation · The systematic construction of a future need from present evidence, resolved before it is felt.

The anticipation loop · Observe, infer, prepare, withdraw. In that order, every time.

The preference file · The written record of a household's preferences, patterns and standing decisions. Boring by design, confidential by rule.

Standing decision · Something the principal has already decided, recorded so they never have to decide it again.

Threshold · The limit, usually unspoken, beyond which you must ask: spend, delay, deviation.

Anomaly · A departure from an established pattern. Either a problem forming or a preference changing.

Mise en place · Everything in its place, before it is needed.

The reset · The nightly return of the house to its baseline state.

The pre-mortem · Assuming the failure has already happened, and writing down what it was.

The second option · The prepared alternative, held privately and never announced.

Over-anticipation · Acting on a need you invented rather than observed.

Presumption · Crossing from removing friction into deciding on their behalf.

Self-assessment

Answer in writing, before the practice.

1. Define anticipation in one sentence, and explain what makes it different from a good guess.
2. Place these on the three-level scale, and justify each: booking a car when asked; offering to book a car; the car being downstairs.
3. Name the six categories of observation, and give one real example of each from your own life this week.
4. What are the five things that must never appear in a preference file?
5. Write out the four movements of the anticipation loop, and explain why the fourth is the difficult one.
6. You enter a room and the atmosphere is heavy. What do you change, and what do you never change?
7. Run a pre-mortem on a dinner for twelve at a restaurant, on a Friday, in winter. Give three specific failures and their second options.
8. Give three examples of over-anticipation, and explain why being right would not have saved you.
9. List everything you would always ask about, without exception, and explain the principle that unites the list.
10. Where, honestly, is your own tendency: reactive, proactive, or anticipatory? What is the single habit that would move you up one level?

Further study

- **Keep the observation log for seven days.** Ten minutes each evening, the six categories, on your own life or a household you know. It will feel pointless on day two and obvious on day six.
 - **Count your questions for one day.** Every question you asked that better preparation would have answered. Write the number down. Do it again in a month.
 - **Read on mise en place**, from the kitchen rather than from the service literature. The chefs write about it more honestly, because for them it is survival rather than style.
 - **Run one pre-mortem on something real this week.** Anything: a journey, a meeting, a dinner. Then compare what actually went wrong with what you predicted. That comparison is the whole lesson.
-

Maison Amarine · The Private Concierge Academy · Confidential, for the use of our mentees only